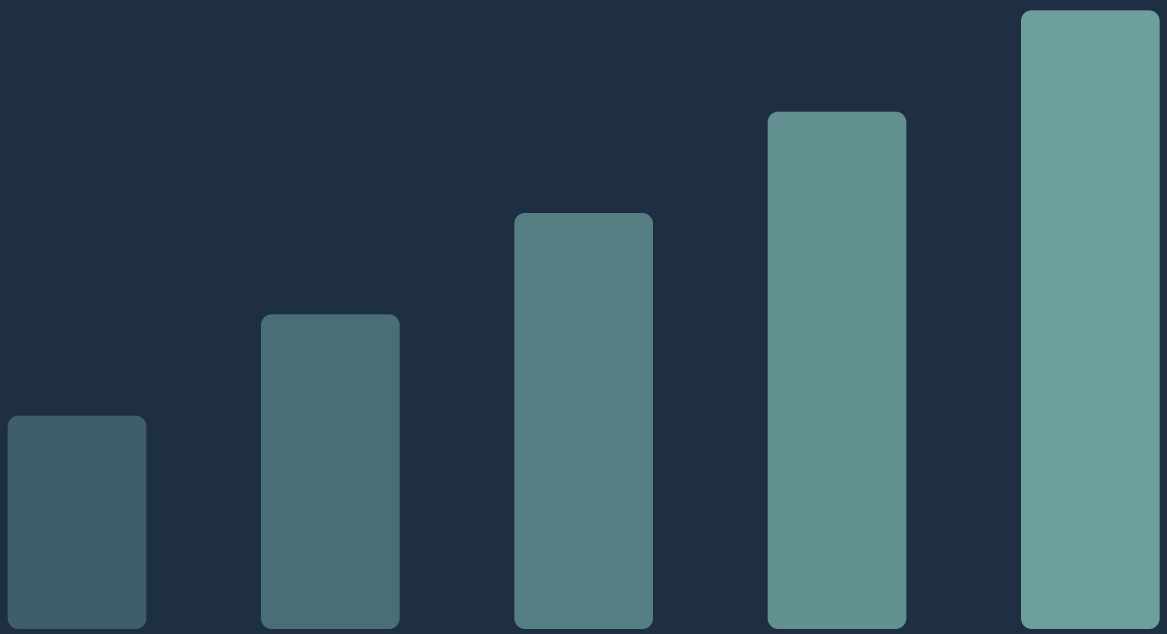
VELLUM PRESS

FREELANCE & WORK

Gulf Job Search

ATS CV and applications



A DIGITAL GUIDE

Saudi & Gulf Job-Search and ATS CV Kit

This kit is a structure for a CV and for the pages around it: a cover letter, a LinkedIn draft, and a tracker. It is written for people applying in Saudi Arabia and elsewhere in the Gulf. It is not a promise of an interview, a visa, or a job.

Applicant systems differ. Some are strict. Some are a person reading a PDF. Follow the posting when it disagrees with a general rule in this file. Do not invent a metric to look stronger.

> Work disclaimer. This guide is education about CVs, applications, and interviews. It is not a promise of an interview, a job, a visa, or a salary. Hiring rules, Saudization, iqama professions, and what an employer's screening software does depend on that employer and on the country. Read the posting. Where a rule affects your right to work, ask the employer or a qualified adviser. Do not invent numbers on a CV.

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01

How to use this guide

Build one file in the language of the posting you are sending it to. Then stop polishing and send it. A fourth typeface will not repair a vague bullet.

- Read the posting once for the work, and once for the words they use for the tools.
- Use those words when they are true of you. Do not paste a skill you cannot demonstrate.
- Keep a tracker. Memory is a bad archive of where you applied.
- If a form asks for something this guide told you to leave off, follow the form.

> Not a promise of employment. Not immigration advice. Not a claim about any employer's screening software.

02

What a screener actually receives

Many employers run an application through software before a person reads it. That software is often called an ATS. The University of Virginia career center, checked on 27 October 2026, says images, columns, tables, and graphics are difficult for those systems to read. It says text inside a text box is often not read, and that most systems cannot read a phone number or email that lives only in the header or footer. That is one office. You cannot see which system a given employer uses. Treat the plain file as a precaution, not as a map of every Gulf portal. The safer file is the one that still makes sense if only the plain text survives.

UVA career center: safer	What that page says many systems mishandle
A single column of text	Columns, including a template built on invisible tables
Standard headings: Skills, Work Experience, Education	A unique heading such as What I've Done
Simple bullet points	Intricate symbols in place of simple bullets
Name, phone, and email in the body	Those details left only in the header or footer

A human reader still has to understand the file in a minute. Plain structure helps that person too. You do not need a decorative CV to be taken seriously.

03

One column, plain headings

Use this order unless the posting demands another. Put the contact line in the body, under your name, not only in the header.

• Name.

• City and country. Phone. Email. LinkedIn or portfolio URL if you have one you are willing to have read.

• Experience: employer, title, city, dates, then bullets.

• Education: school, credential, year.

• Skills: tools and languages you can show, as words, not as a bar chart.

• Optional, if it is short: a three-line summary. Skip it if it only says you are passionate.

File type: if the portal says PDF, send PDF. If it says a Word file, send that. Do not send a picture of a CV. Do not put the important words inside a table, and do not put them in a text box. The same career-center page says tables and text boxes are difficult for those systems to read, and that text inside a text box is often not read. Tables are useful in this guide. They are a poor container for the CV itself.

> **Try this.** Open the file, select all, and paste into a plain text box. If the phone number or the last job disappears, fix the file before you submit it.

04

Dates, language, and two files

Write dates in one calendar, month and year, unless the form asks for Hijri. Mixing Hijri and Gregorian in one date is hard for a reader. If you keep Hijri for your own notes, convert before you type the field. Be consistent down the page. This file does not claim that every parser fails on a mixed date.

Send the language the posting used. A private-sector posting in English gets an English file. An Arabic posting gets an Arabic file. Paragraphs that mix Arabic and English are hard to read because the scripts run in different directions. If the employer needs both, send two files and label them. Do not merge them to save a page.

This PDF is English, and it cannot draw Arabic text correctly. Build the Arabic file in a tool that handles Arabic. Use the same structure: one column, the same jobs, the same true dates.

> Do not put a national ID, iqama number, or passport number on a CV you upload to a general portal. If a secure form has its own field for a number, use that field.

05

Bullets you can prove

One bullet is a verb, the work, and a result you can point to if someone asks. If you do not have a number, do not invent one. 'Shortened the Monday intake' is allowed. 'Improved efficiency by 37 percent' is not allowed unless you can show the 37.

Weak	Stronger, if it is true
Responsible for reports	Built the weekly incident report the team used in the Sunday meeting
Helped customers	Handled the returns desk on the weekend shift, including the refund log
Worked on a project	Name the project and the piece that was yours

Match the posting's tools when you used them. If they ask for Excel and you used it, say what you used it for. If you have not used it, do not add it because the posting listed it.

- ☐ Every job has a title, an employer, and dates.
- ☐ Gaps are a line, not a hole you fill with fiction. A year away can say 'career break' or the true reason you are willing to say.
- ☐ The most relevant role is easy to find, not buried under a graphic.
- ☐ I can talk about any bullet in an interview without looking at the page.

06

Gulf notes

These are limits, not tricks. HRSD's Nitaqat calculator is an employer service. It estimates a band from worker counts and the establishment's activity. A CV template does not make you eligible for a role, and it does not change that band. If a posting says Saudi nationals only, read that line and apply only if it is true of you. Do not adjust a nationality field to fit a template.

Qiwa's help article, read in October 2026, says a worker has 10 days to accept, reject, or request a modification of a pending employment contract. If there is no response, the article says the pending contract is canceled. It does not say that silence counts as acceptance. This PDF cannot tell you whether a job title matches the profession on a residency. Ask the employer or a qualified adviser before you treat an offer as something you can accept.

Elsewhere in the Gulf, private-sector applications are often in English, and public-sector applications often follow that country's own portal. Some employers ask for a photo. Do what the posting says. The same career-center page says images are difficult for applicant systems to read. Leave a photo off unless they asked. This file does not claim that every system rejects a photo, and it does not claim what a reader will think of one.

• Qatar, the UAE, Kuwait, Bahrain, and Oman do not share one CV law. Read the posting.

• Salary history: give it if the form requires it. Do not invent a current salary.

• A driving license, a language, or a certification belongs on the CV only if you have it.

• References: 'available on request' is enough until they ask. Ask each person before you send a name.

> Not immigration advice. Not a reading of any ministry's current rule. Verify the posting and, where your right to work is involved, a qualified person.

07

Cover letter page

A cover letter is four short parts. Fill the brackets with facts. Delete any sentence you would be embarrassed to say out loud.

Part	Write it
Who you are writing to, and the role	
One sentence: the relevant work you have done	
Two sentences: a specific piece of that work, true	
Why this employer, from something you actually read	
How to reach you, and that the CV is attached	

Do not open with 'I am writing to express my interest.' They can see that you applied. Do not claim you have always dreamed of their company unless that sentence is true and specific.

08

LinkedIn headline and About

The headline is one line: the role you do, the field, and who it is for. Example shape, not a line to copy as your life: 'Coordinator in clinic operations, Eastern Province.' Use your real role. Do not stuff the line with words you do not do.

About, three short paragraphs you write

- ☐ What you do now, in two sentences, with the kind of place.
- ☐ One piece of work you can talk about, without a fake percentage.
- ☐ What you want next, stated narrowly enough that a recruiter can tell if you fit.

The experience section should match the CV. Dates that disagree are a reason for a person to stop trusting the file. Recommendations: ask real colleagues, or have none. Do not trade fabricated recommendations.

> **Try this.** Turn off public notifications if you are job-searching quietly and your current employer would be surprised. That is a settings choice, not a ethics lecture.

09

Interview prep

Prepare stories from your own work. A useful shape is: the situation, what you did, what happened. Three stories are enough: a deadline, a disagreement, and a piece of work you are proud of and can explain. Do not memorize a paragraph from a stranger. If you freeze, you will not be able to answer the follow-up.

Question they might ask	The true story I will use	The result I can say
Tell me about yourself		
A deadline		
A disagreement		
Why this role		
A gap or a short job		

Have two questions of your own that are about the work, not only about the salary. Salary may still come up. Know your range from roles you have actually seen, and do not invent a current salary. You can say you are glad to discuss the range for this role.

> An interview is not an offer. A verbal compliment is not an offer. Wait for the written terms before you resign, give notice, or pay a recruiter.

10

Application tracker

One row per application. The point is to know what you sent and when to follow up once. Following up every day does not create a vacancy.

Employer	Role	Date sent	File	Follow-up on	Result

If you have not heard back by the date you wrote, send one short note with the role and the date you applied. Then mark the row and move on. Eight quiet rows are more honest than a story about a market that is 'closed.'

11

Before you submit

Run this list on the file you are about to upload, not on the file you meant to finish. One posting, one pass. Then send it.

- ☐ The file is one column and the contact line survived a paste into plain text.
- ☐ Dates are Gregorian, month and year, unless the form asked for something else.
- ☐ The language matches the posting. A second file is labeled if they asked for both.
- ☐ No photo, chart, or identity number, unless that form required it in its own field.
- ☐ Every bullet is something I can explain. No invented percentage.
- ☐ The filename is my name and the role, not 'CV final final'.
- ☐ The tracker row exists before I close the tab.

A fifteen-minute rewrite

If the list fails, fix the failed line only. Do not redesign the page. A new template on the night you meant to apply is how applications stay unsent. The version you can defend in a conversation is the version you send.

Check	Pass or fix
Plain-text paste still has my phone and last job	
Headings are words, not icons	
Most relevant role is on the first screen	
Cover letter names this role, not a letter pasted from another job	
I can open the file on my phone	

Notes after a conversation

Fill this the same day. A week later you will remember the mood and forget the next step.

Prompt	What I will write
Role and who I spoke with	
What they actually asked	
What I still need to send	
The date I will follow up once	
Anything I should fix on the CV	
Was an offer made in writing? If not, no	

Roles worth a real file

Not every posting deserves a tailored file. Write the ones that do. If you cannot fill the 'why this one' cell from the posting, you are collecting tabs.

Employer and role	Words they used that are	Why this one	Sent?

Employer and role	Words they used that are	Why this one	Sent?

12

A worked example

This is a composite, not a placement. Call her L. She was applying for coordinator roles in the Eastern Province. Her old CV was two columns, with a photo, a skill-bar graphic, and a header that held her phone number.

She rebuilt one English file: contact line in the body, then experience, education, skills. Dates were Gregorian, month and year. Bullets named what she did. Where she had a number she could point to, she used it. Where she did not, she left the number off. She did not write a percentage to look busier.

A posting asked for Arabic. She made a second file instead of mixing scripts in the English one. She left the photo off unless the form asked for one in its own field. She did not put an identity number on the CV.

She tracked eight applications. Two employers wrote back. One interview used a story from her own shift, not a script memorized from a stranger. She did not get every role. The only claim is that the file was readable and the tracker showed what she had actually sent.

If your week does not look like this one, do not force the resemblance. Copy the structure: a baseline, one change at a time, a written review, and a stop when the tool is the wrong tool. The names above are teaching composites, not testimonials and not promises.

13

Field pages

Draft the CV in this order. If a line needs a graphic to make sense, rewrite the line.

CV skeleton

Section	What goes here	Done?
Contact, in the body	Name, city, phone, email, LinkedIn	
Experience	Employer, title, Gregorian dates, bullets	
Education	School, credential, year	
Skills	Tools and languages you can demonstrate	
Left off	Photo, charts, ID number, header-only phone	

Bullet workshop

Role	What I did	Result I can point to	Number? only if true
1			
2			
3			
4			

- ☐ One column. No table inside the CV file.
- ☐ The language matches the posting.
- ☐ A second file exists if they asked for the other language.
- ☐ I did not invent a metric.
- ☐ The tracker has the date I sent it.

14

Thirty-day log

This log is the part you write. Print it. A guide you only read is a brochure. Thirty lines is a month, and a month is long enough to see whether the method fits.

Days 1 to 15

Day	Employer	Role	File sent	Follow-up	Note
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					
7					
8					
9					
10					
11					
12					
13					
14					
15					

Do not backfill a day you forgot. Leave it blank. A blank line is more useful next month than a number you invented. The lines are tall enough to write in, not just to type a checkmark.

Days 16 to 30

Day	Employer	Role	File sent	Follow-up	Note
16					

Day	Employer	Role	File sent	Follow-up	Note
17					
18					
19					
20					
21					
22					
23					
24					
25					
26					
27					
28					
29					
30					

Weekly notes

Week	What repeated	What I will change
1		
2		
3		
4		

Week	What repeated	What I will change
5		

Open notes

	Write in the lines

End of the month

Question	Your answer
What actually repeated?	
What did I abandon, and should it stay abandoned?	
What is the one change for next month?	

Question	Your answer
Do I need a person, not a PDF?	
Where is the file saved on my own device?	

- ☐ I can find this PDF without the download link.
- ☐ The license is mine. I have not posted the file.
- ☐ Next month's first action is written in one sentence.
- ☐ If the guide was the wrong tool, I know what I will do instead.

A last word

Use the pages that match the week you are actually having. Print a worksheet if paper helps you tell the truth. Put the file somewhere you can find it. And if a chapter tells you to talk to a licensed professional, that instruction outranks the rest of the PDF.